



CLIENT TRAINING · MARKETING OPS · TRAFFICKING

Every Link Tells a Story. Make Yours Legible.

Tracking links, publishers, offline media and short-link QR codes in Verilume, for Google Analytics 4 and Adobe Analytics: the value, what you get, and the ten steps that turn "we ran a campaign" into "we know exactly what worked."

Read time: 20 minutes · Setup time: under an hour · Payback: every campaign after

SESSION ONE

Why we are here

Let me start with a question I ask every marketing leader I train: *when your last campaign ended, could you say — with a straight face and a number — which creative, in which channel, drove the visits that turned into revenue?*

Most teams can't. Not because they lack analytics. Because the links they put into the world were anonymous, or tagged in a way the analytics tool could not sort. A direct-mail piece, a magazine ad with a QR code, three email sends, and a paid-social flight all pointed at the same landing page, and the landing page had no way of telling them apart. The dashboard showed "traffic went up," and a big slice of it sat in a bucket called **Unassigned**.

Verilume solves this structurally rather than heroically. You decide the schema once and keep a list of the publishers and partners you buy from. Every link is generated from that list, never typed, and every link is checked against how your analytics tool will file it before it goes anywhere near a printer.

What that gets you

Before	After
"Traffic was up 30% in March."	"The Spring Offer direct-mail drop drove 1,840 visits at \$9.40 each; the magazine QR drove 210 at \$31."
Five people, five spellings of utm_campaign.	One schema, chosen by you, applied by the system. Zero drift.
Offline channels are a black box, or a pile of "Unassigned."	Print, direct mail, radio and events have their own channels in your reports, and every printed piece carries a QR code that resolves to a fully tagged link.
"Meta" in one report, "facebook" in another, "FB" in a third.	One vendor list. The source is always the name your analytics tool recognizes.
A QR code that cannot be fixed once the mailer is printed.	The QR opens a short link you control. The destination can be corrected after printing, and every scan is counted.
Tagging happens at the end, in a rush, if at all.	Tagging happens at trafficking, gated on approved creative, checked and tested before launch.

The stakes

Every dollar of media you spend without a tagged link is a dollar you can't defend in the next budget conversation. That's not a technical problem; it's a credibility problem. The teams that win budget are the ones who can show the receipt. This is how you print the receipt.

SESSION TWO

What's in the box

Six connected pieces. You set up the first three once; the platform takes over from there.

1. Your analytics platform

On the Master UTM configuration card you say which tool reads your links: **Google Analytics 4**, **Adobe Analytics**, or **both** (or leave it to follow the analytics integration you already chose). That one choice changes what a link carries and what the checks look for:

	Google Analytics 4	Adobe Analytics
Captures the campaign	Reads the utm_ parameters on its own.	Does not read UTMs by itself. Reads one tracking code that your tag copies into the campaign variable. Verilume adds that code to every link, in the parameter name you tell it (we suggest cid).
Describes it	Source, medium, campaign, content and term travel as separate parameters.	The single code is expanded into names by a classification file you maintain in Adobe.
Groups it into channels	A built-in default channel group, plus an optional custom channel group.	Marketing Channel processing rules, which you write in Adobe.

2. The link schema

Pick **up to eight** tracking elements from a library of fourteen. Source, medium and campaign are always included, because GA4 requires them, even if you do not tick them. The rest is your house style for measurement.

Element	Parameter	Where the value comes from
Source	utm_source	The publisher or platform from your vendor list: "google", "facebook", "vogue", "dunhill"
Medium	utm_medium	From the vendor and channel, always from a fixed set (see below)
Campaign name	utm_campaign	The campaign's name
Campaign ID	utm_id	Verilume's campaign ID, in the parameter GA4 reads as the campaign ID
Source platform	utm_source_platform	For digital vendors, the ad platform
Creative used	utm_content	The specific approved creative job (or "campaign-level")

Element	Parameter	Where the value comes from
Audience / term	utm_term	The campaign's first target audience segment
Verilume fields (cx_): campaign ID, creative job ID, channel, placement, stage, audience, flight date	cx_campaign_id, cx_creative_id, cx_channel, cx_placement, cx_stage, cx_audience, cx_flight	Verilume's own fields. Nothing in GA4 or Adobe reads them on its own, so pick them only if you will use them (for example in Snowflake).

The fixed set of mediums: cpc, paid-social, display, paid-video, email, referral, affiliate for digital, and direct-mail, print, radio, tv, ooh, event, podcast, qr for offline. Fixed on purpose: your channel rules read the medium, so a new publisher never needs a rule change.

3. The vendor list (where utm_source comes from)

Verilume keeps one list of publishers and partners, and every link picks its source from it. The list has three layers, so you rarely type a vendor name:

Layer	What is in it
Standard Verilume vendors	Google, Microsoft Advertising (Bing), Facebook, Instagram, LinkedIn, TikTok, YouTube, Pinterest, X (Twitter), Reddit, Snapchat, Nextdoor, Yelp, programmatic display, and the common email platforms. Plus generic offline sources (direct mail, print, radio, TV, out-of-home, events, podcasts) for when a job names a channel but no vendor.
Your publisher spec catalog	Every magazine and newspaper in the publisher creative spec catalog, plus any publication your team has added. The publication becomes a vendor automatically.
Partners added by clients	When someone adds a vendor that is not on the list (a cruise site, a luxury newsletter, a mail house), it is saved once and appears for every account. Vendor names are not sensitive, so the list gets better with every client.

Meta is two vendors on purpose.

GA4 recognizes facebook and instagram as social platforms, but not "meta." A link tagged utm_source=meta will not be filed as Paid Social. So Verilume keeps the individual Meta properties: pick Facebook or Instagram, and X uses twitter for the same reason.

4. The channel check on every link

Every link Verilume builds shows what your analytics tool will do with it: the source and medium it chose, the **predicted GA4 channel**, and for Adobe accounts the channel your rules will assign plus the tracking code and its size against Adobe's 255-byte limit. If a link would land in Unassigned, it says so and says how to fix it. The same check runs on any campaign URL you paste in, and also flags uppercase letters and spaces, which GA4 treats as different values.

5. Short links and QR codes

A QR code does not encode the long tracking link. It encodes a short address Verilume owns, which redirects to the tracking link. That gives you four things: a sparse code that scans at small print sizes, a destination you can correct after the piece is printed, a count of QR scans, and a vector (SVG) file for the print vendor. Each creative job keeps one short code for life, so rebuilding its link updates where that code points and never breaks a QR you have already printed.

6. Link testing and the trafficking queue

Before anything goes live, the QR Code & UTM stage in the campaign rail tests every built link from our servers and reports the HTTP status. Marketing Ops has a Tracking Links queue of every creative still needing a link, sorted by due date, so nothing ships untagged.

SESSION THREE

The ten steps to fully optimized

Steps 1 through 4 are done once per account. Steps 5 through 10 happen inside each campaign, and most are already part of the workflow you're running today.

01 Say which analytics tool you use

Go to **Data Management** → **Analytics & Data Inputs** → **Analytics Connections** and scroll to the **Master UTM configuration** card. Under **Analytics platform**, choose GA4, Adobe or both. Adobe accounts also enter the **tracking code parameter** their tag reads (ask your Adobe owner; cid is common, and your tag decides).

02 Choose your schema

Same card. Tap up to eight element chips. My recommended starting set: **Source, Medium, Campaign name, Campaign ID (GA4), Creative used, Audience / term**, plus two Verilume IDs if you join data in a warehouse. Source, medium and campaign are always on.

03 Flip on the per-channel auto-parameters

Below the chips, check **Automatically insert a 1st-party Contact ID on email campaign links**, then enter the parameter name (we suggest `contact_id`) and your ESP's merge tag *exactly* as your ESP spells it:

```
HubSpot {{ contact.hs_object_id }}
Klaviyo {{ person.id }}
Marketo {{lead.id}}
Mailchimp *|SUBSCRIBERID|*
```

Use a pseudonymous ID only, never an email address or a name; GA4 must not receive personal data. Leave **GCLID on Google Ads links** checked unless your Google Ads account auto-tags, and ask your paid-search lead. Save.

04 Put the channel rules into your analytics tool

This is the step that ends "Unassigned." At the bottom of the same card, Verilume prints the rules for the platform you chose, ready to copy.

GA4: create a custom channel group called "Verilume channels" (Admin → Data display → Channel groups) using the list on the card: Paid Search, Paid Social, Paid Video, Display, Email, Direct Mail, Print, Radio, TV, Out-of-Home, Events, Podcast, QR Code, Partner Referral, each keyed to a *medium*. Then tick **"I have added the custom channel group"** so the link check knows.

Adobe: add the Marketing Channel processing rules shown on the card (in order), map your tracking code parameter to the campaign variable, and decide how long the code should persist. Adobe keeps the value by default, so a later visit can be credited to an earlier campaign.

GA4 has no default channel for offline media, so without this step every print, direct-mail and radio link is filed as Unassigned. With it, they are channels.

05 Give every campaign a landing URL

On the campaign's detail page, the **Campaign URL & Conversion Tracking** card needs a saved landing-page URL. The builder constructs the tracking link on top of it. If the URL already carries `utm_` parameters or a `#fragment`, Verilume strips the old parameters, adds the new ones and keeps the fragment last.

06 Approve creative through the normal flow

Run Creative Asset Selection as you already do and press **Send Assets to Creative Team**. That creates one Creative Job per approved asset, and those jobs populate the builder. Give each job its delivery platform (for example "Vogue" or "Facebook feed") so the source is filled in for you.

07 Build the links

Campaign detail → **Ad Trafficking** card. Choose a creative and, if needed, the **Publisher or vendor**. Not on the list? Choose **Add a vendor**, type the name, confirm the type and medium, and it joins the list for every account. Press **Build**.

Read the check under the link. A ✓ means your analytics tool will file it correctly. A ✕ tells you what to fix. The trafficking workspace does the same for every creative on the campaign at once, with one summary of the links that need a look.

Per-creative links are gated: a creative's copy and finished asset must both be approved before its link is saved to the job.

08 Generate QR codes for anything printed

Generate QR code creates (or reuses) the job's short link and shows it, then draws a QR code that opens it. Download the **SVG for print**; it stays sharp at any size. Download the PNG for screens. Give the file to your creative team with the asset.

Below the code you will see the number of QR scans and other visits so far. These count people who reached the redirect, not website sessions.

09 Test before you traffic

In the campaign rail, open the **QR Code & UTM** stage and press **Test tracking links**. A ✓ means the page resolved. A X with a status code means fix the landing page before a single impression runs. Then scan one printed proof with a real phone.

10 Work the queue

Marketing Ops → **Tracking Links** tab. Every creative job that still needs a link, sorted by due date, with Overdue / On schedule / Complete badges. The queue should be empty before launch week.

SESSION FOUR

Offline media: print, direct mail, radio and events

If you buy magazines, newspapers, direct mail, radio, out-of-home or events, this is the session that matters most. Offline is a normal channel in Verilume, not an exception.

You run	Source	Medium	Channel in your reports
A magazine ad (Vogue, Condé Nast Traveler)	the publication, e.g. vogue	print	Print
A newspaper ad	the publication	print	Print
A direct-mail drop	the mail house or program, e.g. aov - dm	direct-mail	Direct Mail
A partner newsletter or sponsored site (Cruise Critic, Smarter Luxury, Sherman's Travel, Dunhill)	the partner	email or referral	Email or Partner Referral
A radio spot or podcast	the station or show	radio / podcast	Radio / Podcast
A billboard or event	the vendor or event	ooh / event	Out-of-Home / Events

Name the vendor

If a creative job says only "Direct Mail" with no vendor, Verilume uses the generic source `direct-mail` and warns you. The link still works, but your report cannot tell one mail house from another. Naming the vendor takes ten seconds and makes the report worth reading.

Print pieces with a QR code

The QR encodes the short link, and the short link redirects to the tagged link, so a piece with a QR and the same piece with a typed web address land on the same tracking link. Verilume counts the QR scans at the redirect, which is where you see the difference. In GA4 and Adobe, the two arrive looking the same.

If you already have printed links in market

Do not rewrite them. Older links carry a channel name such as "search" or "social" as their source. Custom channel groups in GA4 are designed to apply to existing data as well as new data (please confirm this in your own property), so adding the group in step 4 also cleans up how those links are reported, by reading their medium.

Two things to know about Google's own rules.

A paid-style medium (cpc or anything starting with "paid") whose source Google does not recognize is filed as **Paid Other**, not Paid Social or Paid Search. A medium that matches no rule at all, including every offline medium, is filed as **Unassigned**. The check on each link tells you which of these applies before you traffic it.

What finished links look like

A magazine ad in an Adobe and GA4 account, built from the vendor list, with the tracking code and the QR short link:

```
https://www.yourbrand.com/spring-offer
?utm_source=vogue
&utm_medium=print
&utm_campaign=spring-offer-2027
&utm_id=cmp-8f31a2
&utm_content=full-page
&cid=cmp-8f31a2_vogue_print_job-44c1
```

The tracking code has four parts, always in this order: **campaign ID, publisher, medium, creative**, separated by underscores and all lowercase. Adobe's classification file expands that one value into readable columns. The QR code on the page encodes only the short address, for example yourdomain/r/Ab3xK9.

```
https://www.yourbrand.com/spring-offer
?utm_source=mailchimp&utm_medium=email
&utm_campaign=spring-offer-2027&utm_id=cmp-8f31a2
&utm_content=email-hero-600x400
&contact_id={{ contact.hs_object_id }}
```

Coaching notes from the field

Pick eight and stop.

The limit exists so links stay readable and your analytics tool doesn't truncate. Choose the dimensions you'll actually filter by in a dashboard.

Consistency beats cleverness.

Once you've set the schema and the vendor names, don't change them mid-year. Every change creates a "before" and "after" that won't compare. Vendor slugs are what your reports group on, so treat them like column headings.

The merge tag is the one thing you can get wrong.

Verilume inserts your Contact ID token verbatim, exactly as typed, because your ESP has to recognize it. If your emails go out with a literal "{{ contact.hs_object_id }}" in the link, the tag is spelled differently from what your ESP expects. Send yourself a test email.

Print the QR code at the right size.

Short-link codes are sparse, so they scan well small, but keep them at least 2 cm (0.8 in) square, larger for anything read at a distance. Leave a blank border of at least four squares and never place the code over a photo. Always send the SVG to the printer.

Test links are free. Un-testable print runs are not.

Run "Test tracking links" every time a landing page changes, and scan a printed proof before the run. A short link can be repointed after printing; a wrong tracking link on a printed code without one cannot.

Adobe teams: watch how long the code persists.

Adobe keeps the campaign value for a period after the visit (commonly 30 days), so a later organic visit can inherit an earlier paid code. Decide the expiration with your Adobe owner and write it down.

SESSION FIVE

Who does what, and your launch checklist

Role	Owns	When
Marketing leadership	Approves the schema and the vendor names behind it.	Once, at onboarding; revisit annually.
Analytics owner (GA4 or Adobe)	Adds the channel rules from step 4; confirms the tracking code parameter and how long it persists; sets up the dashboard views.	At onboarding; on any schema change.
Email / CRM owner	Supplies the ESP merge-tag syntax; validates with a test send.	At onboarding; when the ESP changes.
Performance marketing	Sets each campaign's landing URL; approves creative assets; names the delivery platform on each job.	Every campaign.
Marketing Ops / trafficking	Builds links and QR codes, clears every X in the channel check, runs link tests, clears the Tracking Links queue.	Every campaign, before launch.
Creative team	Places the QR code on printed pieces at the right size, using the SVG.	Every printed asset.
Print and mail vendors	Receive the SVG QR file and the proof approval; scan a proof before the run.	Every printed run.

Launch checklist

Item	Where
Analytics platform chosen (and Adobe code parameter entered)	Analytics Connections
Master UTM configuration saved with your chosen elements	Analytics Connections
Contact ID token entered and verified with a test email	Analytics Connections
GA4 custom channel group and/or Adobe channel rules added, and the GA4 box ticked	Your analytics tool; Analytics Connections
Campaign landing URL saved	Campaign detail → Campaign URL card
Every creative job names its delivery platform or vendor	Creative Jobs
A tracking link built for every approved creative, every channel check ✓	Campaign detail → Ad Trafficking
QR codes generated; SVG handed to creative for every printed piece	Campaign detail → Ad Trafficking
All links tested — every one shows ✓; a printed proof scanned	Campaign rail → QR Code & UTM
Tracking Links queue shows nothing overdue for this campaign	Marketing Ops → Tracking Links
Dashboard view filtered on the campaign ID or name	Your analytics tool

The closing thought

You don't get credit for the campaigns you ran. You get credit for the ones you can explain. An hour of setup makes every campaign after it explainable, down to the publisher and the creative, in print as well as online, and it does so without asking anyone to remember anything. That's the trade. Take it.

Questions or a walkthrough with your team: reach your Verilume account lead.